Meridian Glass

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Chapter 1

The workshop smelled of sand and heat and something else -- something mineral, a smell that had no common name but that Nana had associated, since childhood, with the moment before things changed form. Her grandfather called it the smell of possibility, which she had always found romantic to the point of embarrassment. After twenty years, she simply called it home.

She arrived in the early morning, before anyone else, the way she always arrived on days she needed to think. The furnace had been banked overnight and the glass pots still held the remnants of yesterday's work -- a green that her grandfather had mixed in the 1970s from a formula written in a notebook she could no longer read, because he had written it in a Twi script that mixed two dialects in a way only he had spoken. She had had it translated once, years ago, when he was still alive and could correct the translator's mistakes. She had the corrected version somewhere. The formula still worked. She did not fully understand why.

The workshop was arranged the same way it had been arranged in 1963, when Kofi Boateng had built it on a plot of rented land in what was then the outer edge of Kumasi. The furnace at the back, the glory hole to its left, the marver table to the right, the bench running the length of the north wall where finished pieces cooled in sequence of their making. Her grandmother's hand was in the arrangement; Kofi had told Nana this more than once, as if it mattered that the spatial logic of the workshop had been, from the beginning, a collaboration. Her grandmother had been a trader, not a maker. She had understood the importance of the movement of bodies through space, and had seen, in Kofi's first rough sketch of the workshop floor, something that could be improved.

Nana set her bag on the bench and stood for a moment at the entrance, looking in. The light at this hour came through the north window at a low angle and caught the finished pieces on their stands in a way that made each one briefly remarkable. This was the time of day she felt, most acutely, the weight of the thing she had agreed to continue.

Part I, Chapter 9

Abena left the workshop on a Thursday morning in November 1994, which is to say she left it the way her mother had told her she eventually would: in the middle of something unfinished, without ceremony, with no particular plan. The piece she had been working on was a vessel for storing palm wine, the kind her grandfather had made in the early years. Functional, nothing decorative. She had been trying for three weeks to get the neck right and she had not gotten it right yet.

She put down the blowpipe. She turned off the secondary furnace. She did not lock the door -- she had never locked the door, because her grandfather had never locked the door, on the grounds that anyone desperate enough to steal glass from a glass workshop in this neighborhood probably needed it more than he did. She walked out through the front of the workshop onto the street, which smelled in the morning of bread and exhaust and the particular quality of dust that Kumasi dust had -- different from Accra dust, she had always thought, though she had only been to Accra twice and could not have said exactly why.

She did not know, walking out, that she would not return for eleven years. She thought she was leaving for a week, perhaps two. She had a cousin in Accra who had offered her work in a printing office. She had sixty cedis in her bag and a change of clothes. She thought she was stepping back; it turned out she was stepping away.

The workshop sat empty for a month before a neighbor, old Asante, started sleeping there at night to keep away the boys from the road. Nana would learn this from him, years later, and would feel something she could not name -- gratitude, but also grief, because the grief came first and the gratitude came after, which is the order those things usually arrive.